

1. For any accurate sense experience, I can imagine a situation which is indistinguishable from that sense experience but in which my environment is not as the experience says it is.
2. There are situations which I cannot rule out which would make beliefs formed on the basis of sense experience false.
(1)
3. If you cannot rule out a situation which would make P false, you should not believe P. (Doubt $\rightarrow$ No Belief)
4. You should not form beliefs on the basis of sense experience. (2,3)
5. Sense experience is your only source of information about the world outside of you.

C. You should not form any beliefs about the world outside of you. (4,5)

AN ARGUMENT FOR SKEPTICISM ABOUT THE EXTERNAL WORLD

The conclusion of this argument is quite surprising. Can it really be true that we should withhold forming any beliefs about the world around us?

It is tempting to think that we should be able to respond to these arguments by constructing an argument which would show that our sense experiences are reliable.

But it turns out that this is very hard to do.

We might try to construct an argument based on science. For example, science tells us that our visual experiences are caused by light reflecting off of the surface of physical objects and interacting with our eye, causing effects in our visual cortex. Given this, don't the existence of our sense experiences show that there must be physical objects around us to reflect light?

But there's an immediate problem here. The scientific theories on which this reply relies are themselves based on sense experience. So if we rely on those theories, we are tacitly relying on the very thing — the reliability of our sense experiences — which we were trying to establish.



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It is tempting to think that we should be able to respond to these arguments by

constructing an argument which would show that our senses are reliable.

finding a way to show that certain experiences are not illusions.

For example, one might argue that, since our senses are usually

accurate, it is reasonable to form beliefs about the external world on their basis.

Presumably on the basis of past experience. And those experiences can be

doubted just as much as our present experience. The attempt to respond to

reliability of past sense experiences to go in a circle.

defend the reliability of our current sense experiences on the basis of the

But how do we know that our sense experiences are usually accurate?

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